

THE FIGHT OVER 50 PER CENT

Madhya Pradesh, Karnataka become the latest frontlines in a quota war poised to intensify with the Census. State after state is pushing to breach the legal ceiling on caste reservations

By Rahul Noronha

It's one thing to imagine caste as a 'perennial factor' in Indian politics. Quite another to measure the velocity of change in the here and now. Capture the urgency from one fact: just in October, one Supreme Court ruling and two separate high court orders, in Madhya Pradesh and Karnataka, pushed back against states moving to break the 50 per cent cap on caste-based reservations. It's a livewire issue in a third major state, Maharashtra. In recent years, at least nine states have attempted to expand education and job